

Ergonomic Hammer Art

Sculptre TA, Oberlin

During my time as the sculpture TA where I oversaw the sculpture lab and woodshop, a beloved space filled with well-used tools and paint-splattered stools. I began a small project that eventually became known to the students as Ergonomic Hammer Art. Wanting to give these objects another life, I hand-whittled new grips from shop scraps, sanding and shaping each one to fit more comfortably in students' hands, then polished and reassembled the hammer heads to upgrade rather than replace them. I did the same with our stools, stripping back the old finish and giving them a cosmetic update using the laser cutter etching images of the shop, its tools, and even the safety signage I had created onto them. I invited students to contribute their own designs, making the space feel more shared and cared for, and encouraging a studio culture where everyone felt responsible for keeping it alive and usable. Many of the ergonomic hammers were eventually “shoplifted” by students, something I can only take as a compliment and though I wish I had better photos, the project remains one of my favorites I created in the shop.

